

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

NO TIME OR MONEY TO WASTE

On September 13, the opposition INDIA bloc announced in Delhi that a rally would be held in Bhopal in October. However, soon after, there was another communiqué saying it had been cancelled, reportedly because Madhya Pradesh Congress chief Kamal Nath was against holding it in the state. Some said that the state Congress did not want to be on the same stage with AAP and SP as both parties were fielding candidates in MP in the upcoming assembly polls. The real reason, though, seems to be more pragmatic. The Congress is the main opposition party in the state and doesn't need allies. Nath, being a seasoned politician, did not want to spend money on organising an event that is unlikely to yield him any electoral dividend.

Costly Faux Pas





In the desert duel between Rajasthan chief minister **Ashok Gehlot** and Union Jal Shakti minister **Gajendra Singh Shekhawat,** this round goes to the latter. On September 19, a Delhi court dismissed Gehlot's appeal to quash a defamation case Shekhawat had filed against him. The Congress leader, based on a police investigation, had first accused the Union minister and his family members of swindling investors' money in the Sanjeevani Cooperative Society case. But in another case, Gehlot's lawyer Abhishek Singhvi had claimed there was no case against Shekhawat, prompting the latter to file the defamation case. Singhvi later amended his stand, but the damage was done.

PUZZLING SILENCE

While Canada PM **Justin Trudeau's** allegation of New Delhi's complicity in the assassination of Khalistan Tiger Force chief Hardeep Nijjar has got the entire BJP machinery up in arms, the Punjab unit has maintained a relative quiet. The state BJP did organise protests in front of the Canada consulate office in Chandigarh on September 19, but called it off later at the instructions of Punjab unit chief Sunil Jakhar. This is certainly a role reversal for the saffron party in Punjab, going soft on Khalistani elements. Incidentally, Nijjar is alleged to be the mastermind in the 2016 murder of then state RSS chief, Jagdish Gagneja.



MANISH RAJPUT

Kaushik Deka with Rahul Noronha, Rohit Parihar, Ajay Sukumaran, Arkamoy Datta Majumdar and Anilesh S. Mahajan

UPFRONT



A Case of Too Many Deputies

Just as Karnataka deputy CM **D.K. Shivakumar** was settling into his hard-won post as the state's No. 2 leader, there's now a call—from a fellow minister at that—for having three more deputy CMs to better represent the various communities ahead of the 2024 Lok Sabha election. That the pitch came from cooperation minister K.N. Rajanna, a known loyalist of CM Siddaramaiah, further muddies the waters.



STEELY MOVE

Former Indian cricket skipper **Sourav Ganguly** has apparently broken the hearts of Bengal BJP leaders with his announcement of investing Rs 2,500 crore to set up a steel plant in Salboni, West Midnapore. Ganguly, who was once billed as a possible BJP nominee for the CM's post, is currently touring Spain as a member of a state contingent seeking investments. Following the announcement, BJP leader Sukanta Majumdar, who had at one point pitched the idea of Ganguly "as Kolkata's Sheriff", wondered when the ex-cricketer had turned into an industrialist. Leader of the Opposition Suvendu Adhikari pointed out how Ganguly had been acquiring swathes of land for a long time but had never set up a business.